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Passages for Words, or the Sculptural Practice of Philippe Maucotel

Philippe Maucotel was born in 1940 and died in 2020. He was born in France, where he studied literary theory at the Sorbonne in Paris. He emigrated to the United States in 1962 and worked until the end of his life in his studio in Cutchogue. He is the author of numerous solo and group exhibitions in the United States and Europe. His fascination with sculpture began with literature, with poetry that may focus on the observation of a single word or even a single letter. Poetry is a specific laboratory of language, and its openness allows one to observe the possibilities of language.

In Philippe Maucotel's work, there is a fascination with words and their possible forms, which do not close meaning into fixed form but rather function as attempts at materialization. Their arrangement, shape, medium, and scale explore the possibilities of meaning. Words, which are abstract, need or may become material; they may become part of a landscape shaped by the artist. Their appearance in nature is connected with processes to which they will be subject. The possibility, and even necessity, of destruction is inscribed in the work—their crumbling and disappearance in nature. This potential for disintegration is also a story about the fragility of words understood as declarations or promises.

The sculptor wrote of himself that he “sculpts himself.” What might such a statement mean? If we look closely at Philippe Maucotel's artistic practice, we notice that he cut letters into fences, plywood, and variously treated barriers that can be understood as boundaries or dams. Cutting specific words into them gives the viewer the possibility of passage, an opening through which visual poetry continues.

The artist submerged cut or sculpted letters and words, placed them in aquariums, and arranged them like children's toys or everyday objects, shifting and testing their capacity to operate within different spatial contexts. These sculptural actions contain considerable melancholy and at times irony, but also much humor, which allows us to distance ourselves from language that, once materialized, becomes more earthly. At the same time, through matter, one can find analogies to layered plywood structures from which a single word is built.

If language can be understood as a tool for modeling the world, Maucotel attempted to present it as a finished model, examining individual letters and word-definitions in their possible precision or relativity.

In his work, one can find affinities with conceptual artists (Ian Hamilton Finlay), Dadaists (Marcel Duchamp, Francis Picabia), and Pop Art in relation to their linguistic operations in space. However, Philippe Maucotel remains a deeply original artist, as his method of cutting letters bears his individual handwriting (with a more emotional and personal trace of meaning).

Maucotel's work can be read both as visual poetry in space and as sculpture that realizes itself through the possible form of words. Regardless of whether one interprets his sculptural practice as

possible poetry or as objects that become letters, it remains a distinctive record in both American and global art.

Particular attention should be paid to the subtle combination of humor in his artistic practice, where the moment of disintegration of letters—and, by extension, metaphor or language more broadly—is not a catastrophe but a necessity connected to openness toward indeterminacy, toward the freedom that poetry can also offer. Disintegration is as important as construction. In the process of deconstruction of physical representations of words, layers appear, surfaces and fissures are revealed, cracks through which water, light, and earth pass. Language thus ceases to be a dam of movement and becomes part of it. The stratification of sculptural forms points to repetitions and accumulations of a single word/meaning, but over time their rhythm becomes disrupted—the layers are no longer compact, becoming only flakes, epidermal traces of meaning in their transience and ephemerality. Words cease to function as advertising carriers of information and become possible exits, still with a defined shape, but extending beyond their former meanings.

Maucotel's sculptural work complements many artistic and scholarly approaches concerning the activation of poetic metaphor in contemporary art. His works and installation documentation can be seen in the studio where he worked in Cutchogue, and his artistic legacy is cared for by Bożena Skuriat-Królik, who initiated the Artistic Foundation named after Philippe Maucotel.